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(54) **OPTICAL BRANCH CABLE AND OPTICAL
BRANCH CABLE SET**

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(57) **ABSTRACT**

An optical branch cable includes a main cable and a branch cord portion. The main cable includes a plurality of optical cords each including at least one optical fiber core wire, a tension member, and a tape forming an outermost layer. At least one optical fiber core wire of the branch cord portion is led out from the optical cords of the main cable to an outer side of the outermost layer. The optical branch cable includes an optical cord group and a core portion. The optical cord group includes the plurality of optical cords bundled by a first bundle. The core portion includes the optical cord group and the tension member bundled by a second bundle. The tape is wrapped by longitudinal wrapping around the core portion to cover the core portion.

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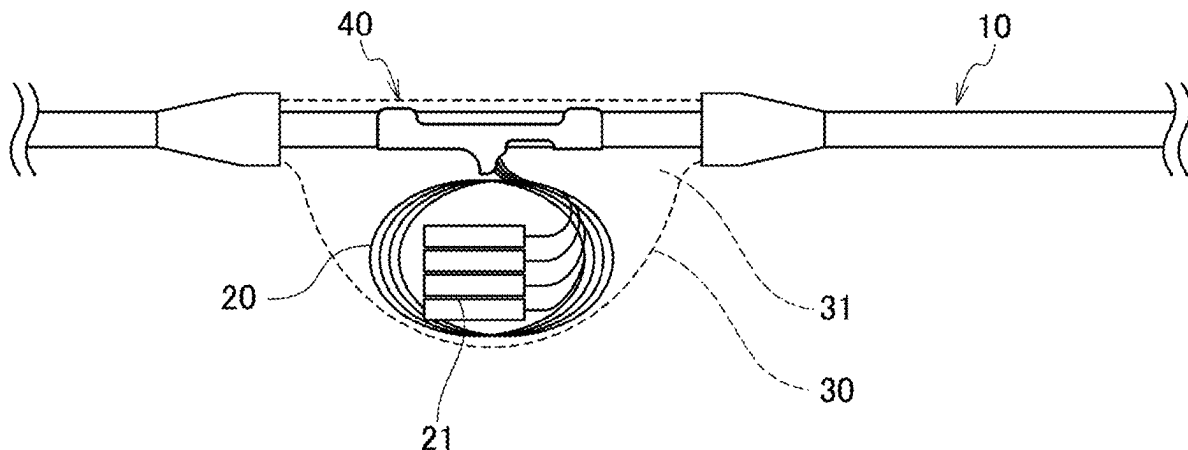


FIG. 1

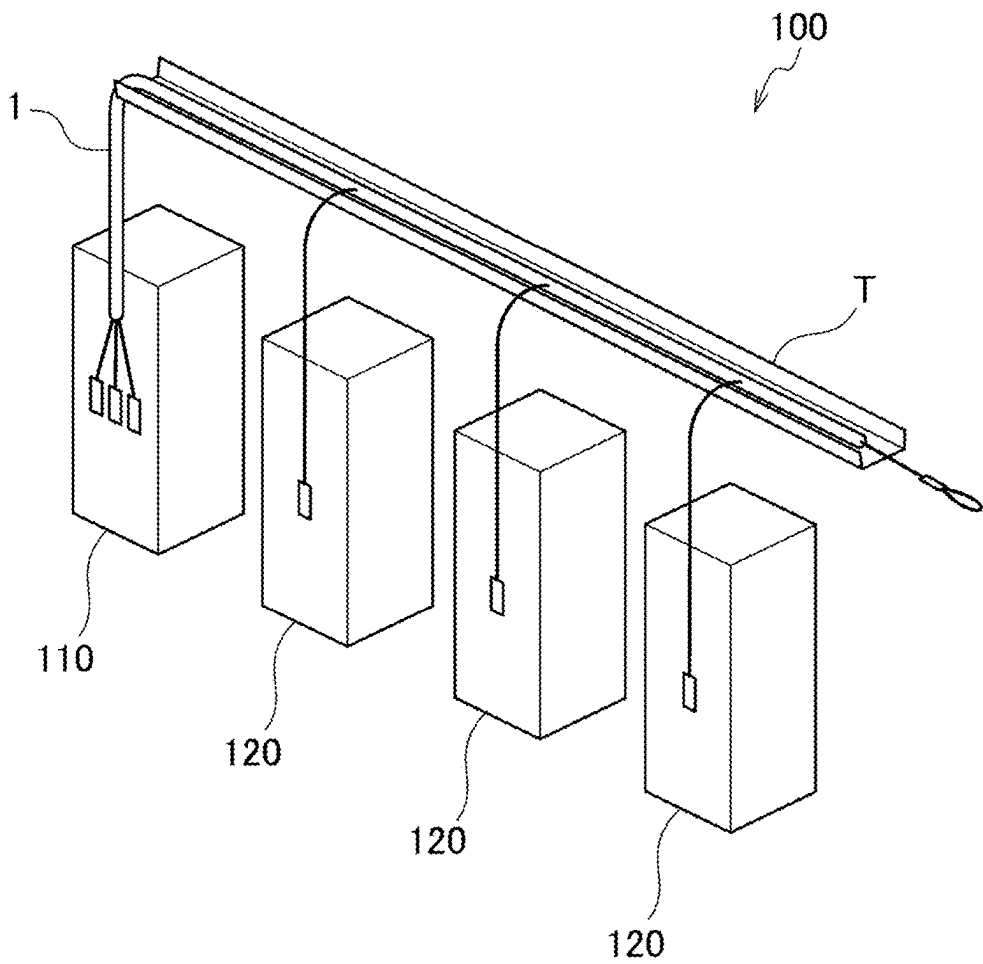


FIG.2

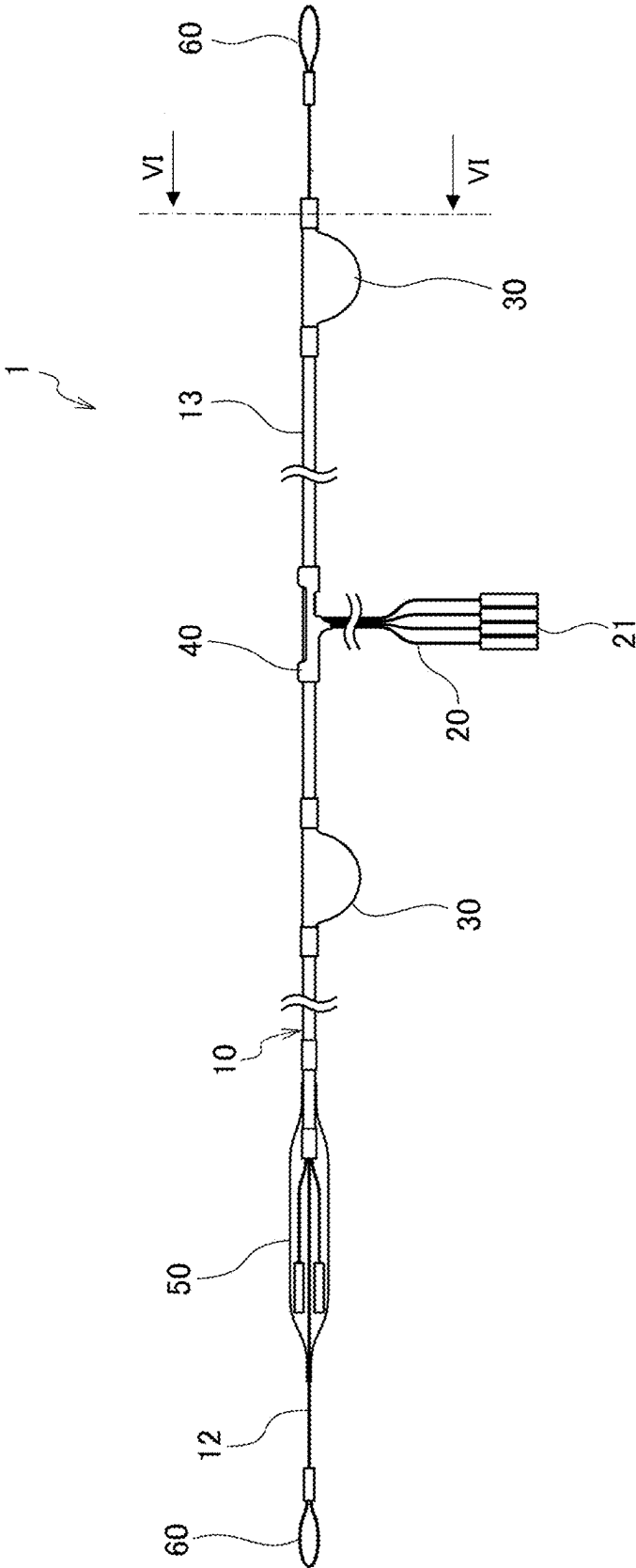


FIG.3

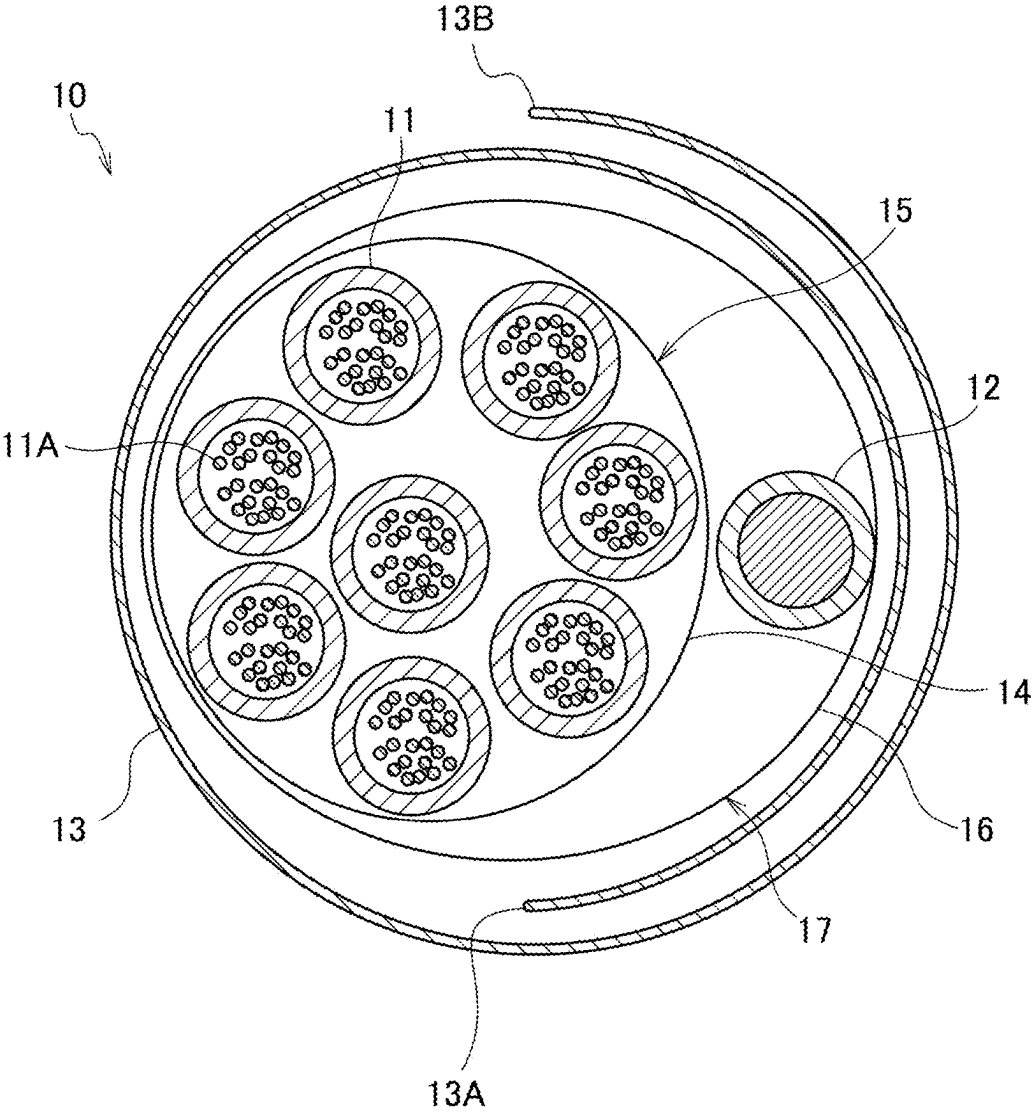


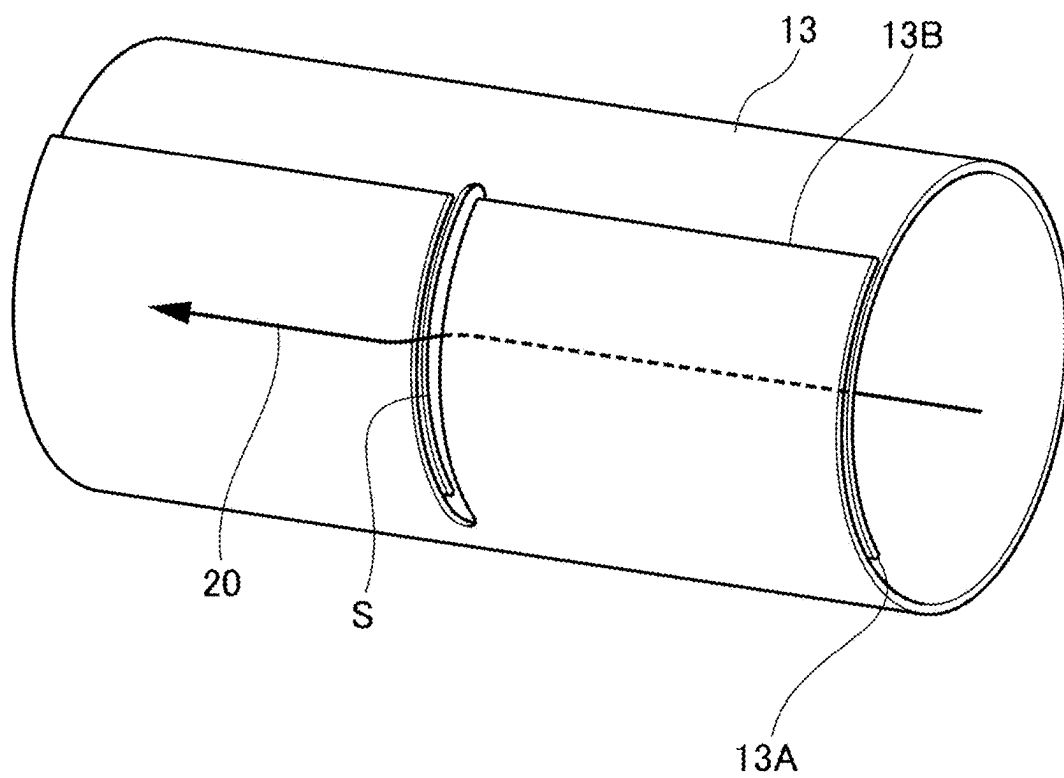
FIG. 4

FIG.5

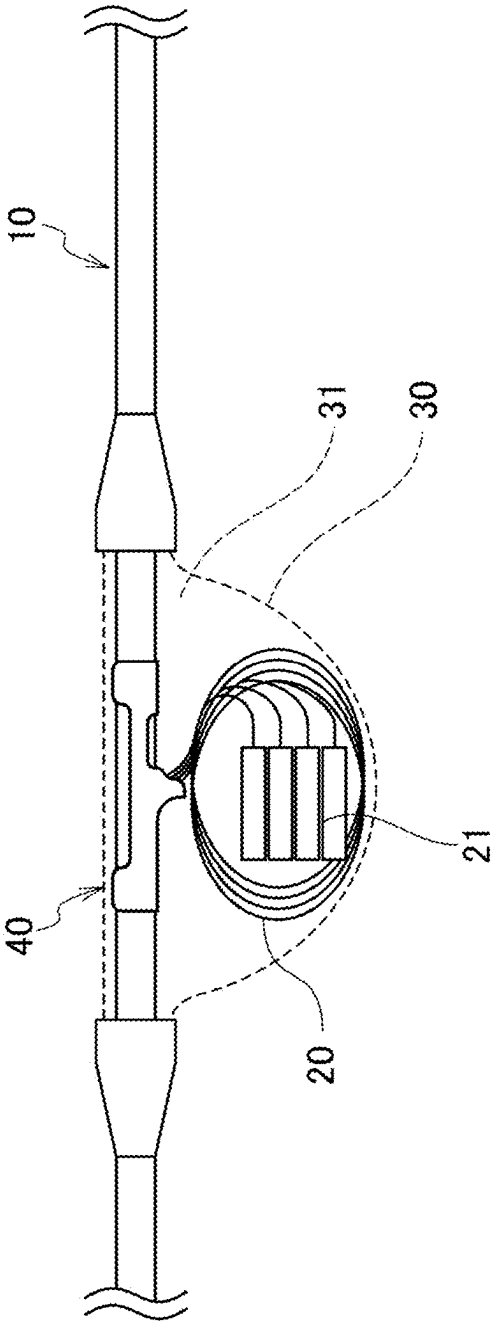


FIG. 6

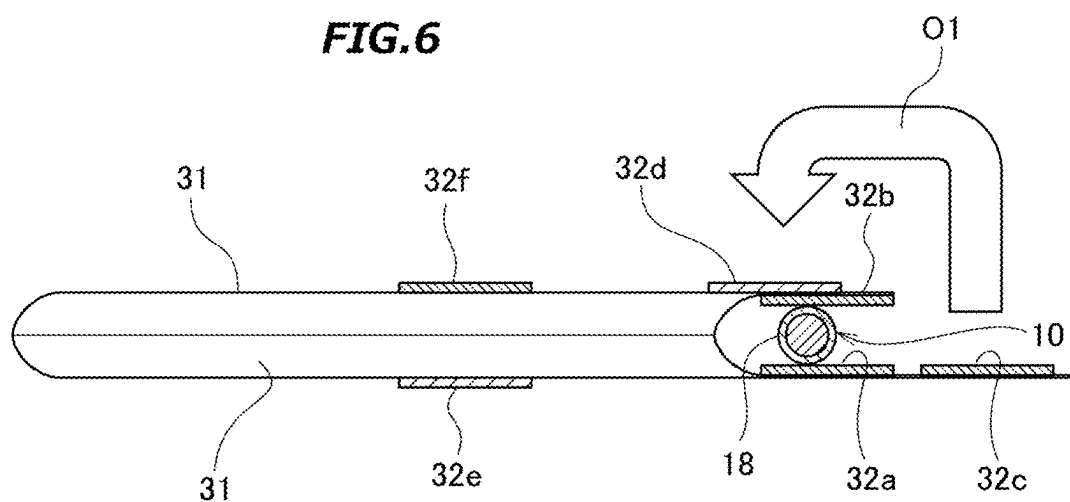
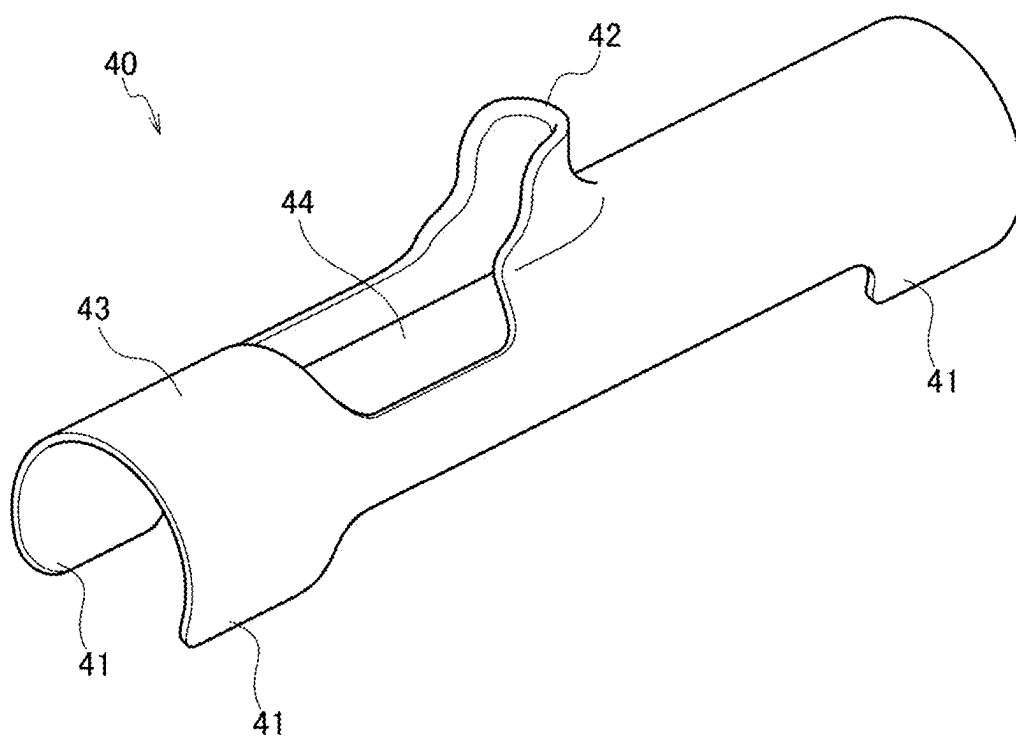


FIG. 7



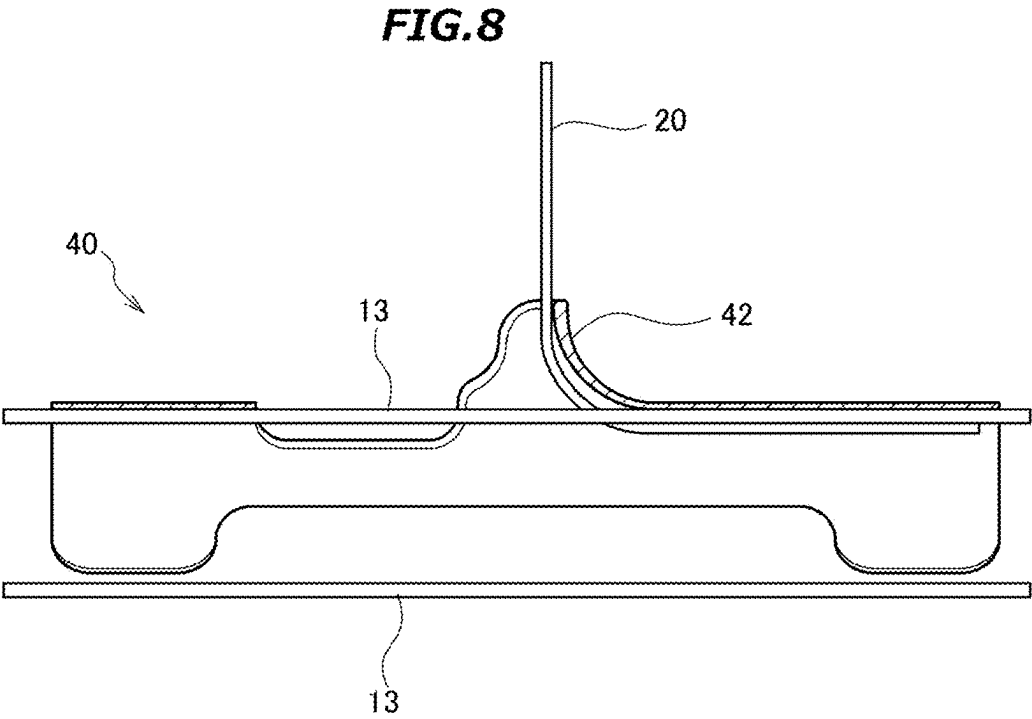


FIG. 9

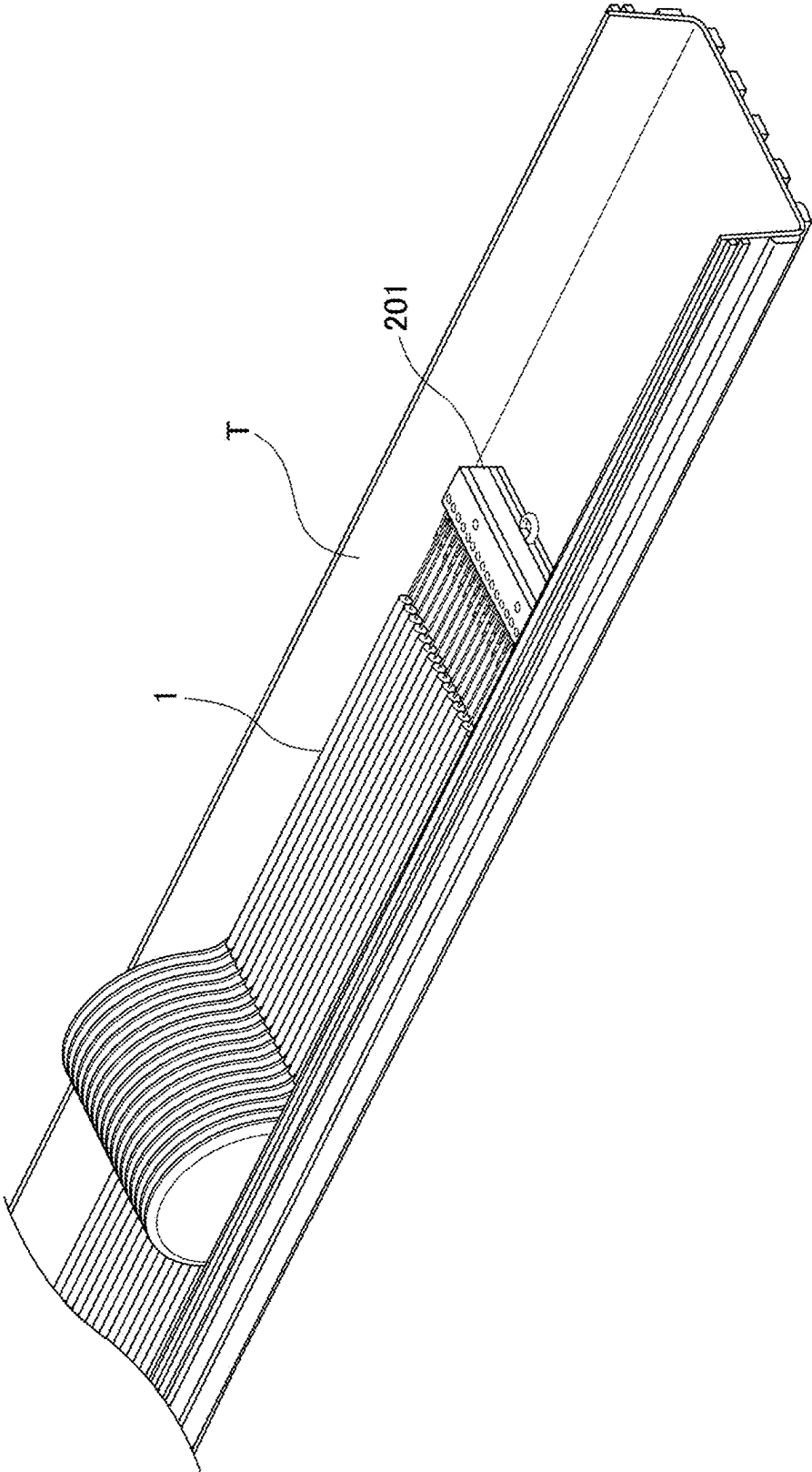


FIG.10

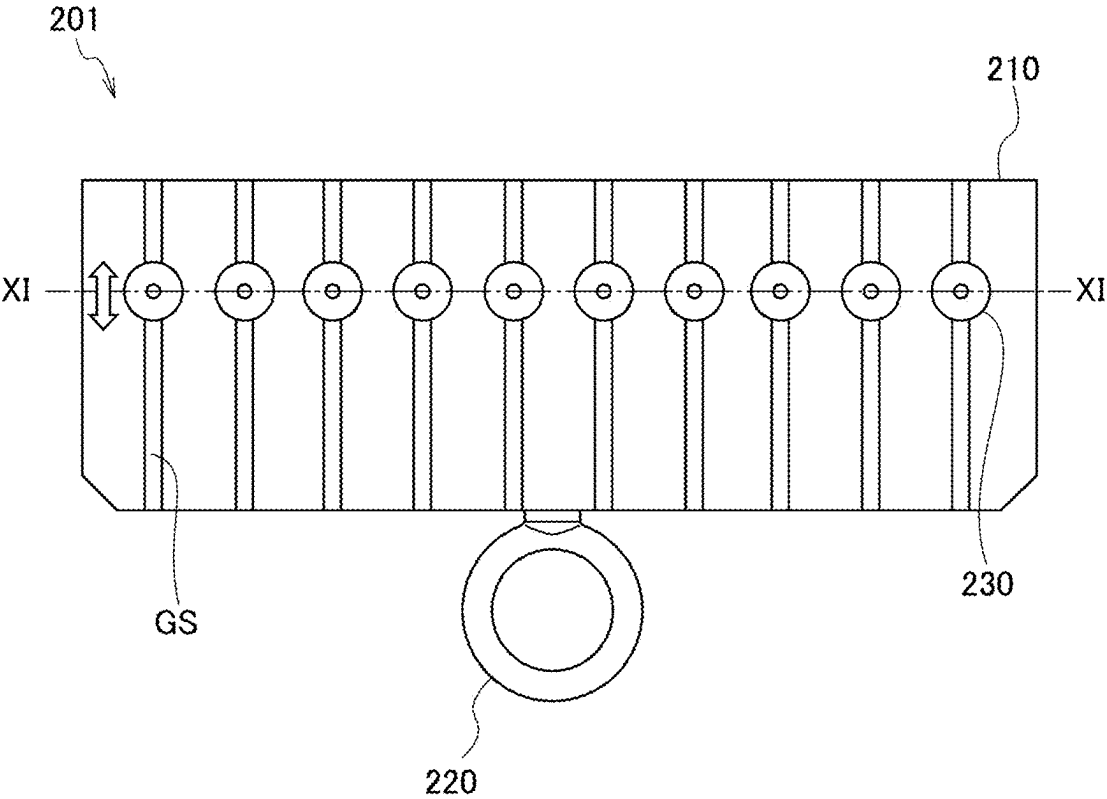


FIG. 11

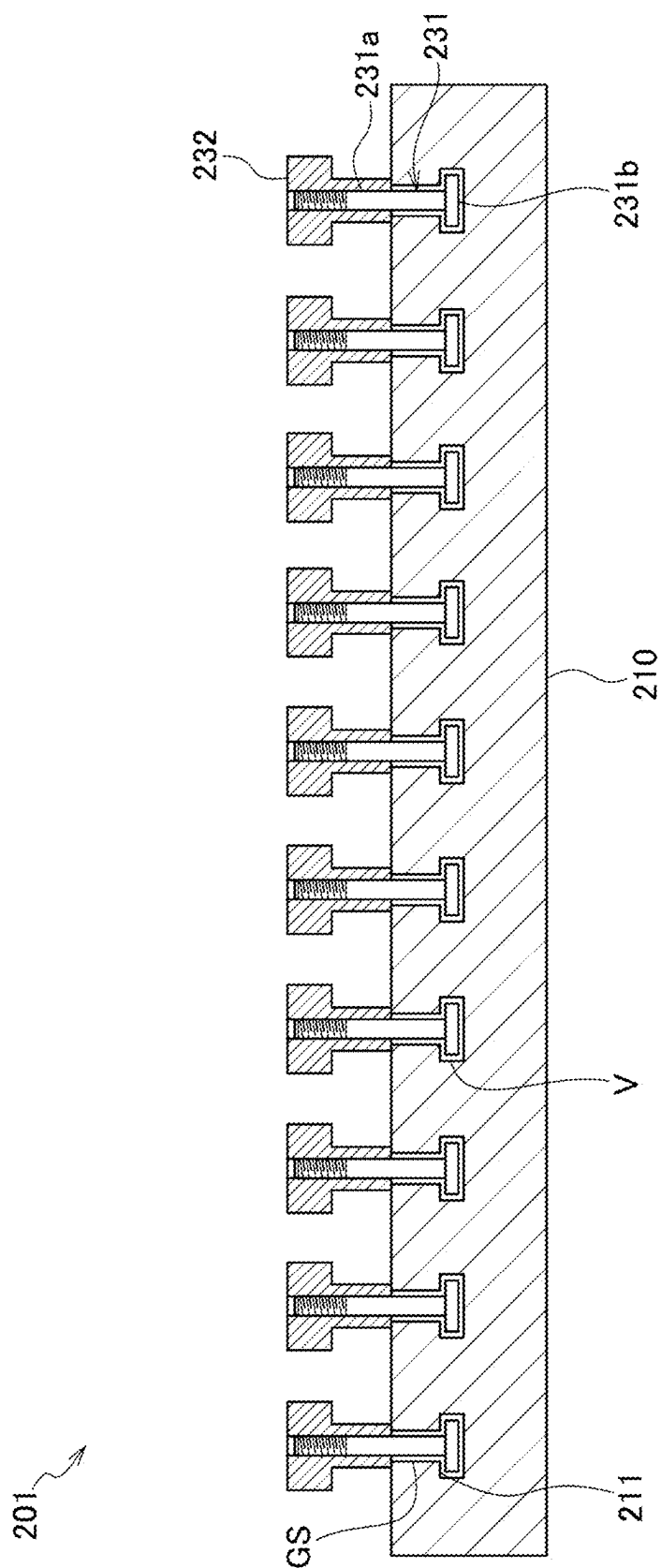


FIG.12

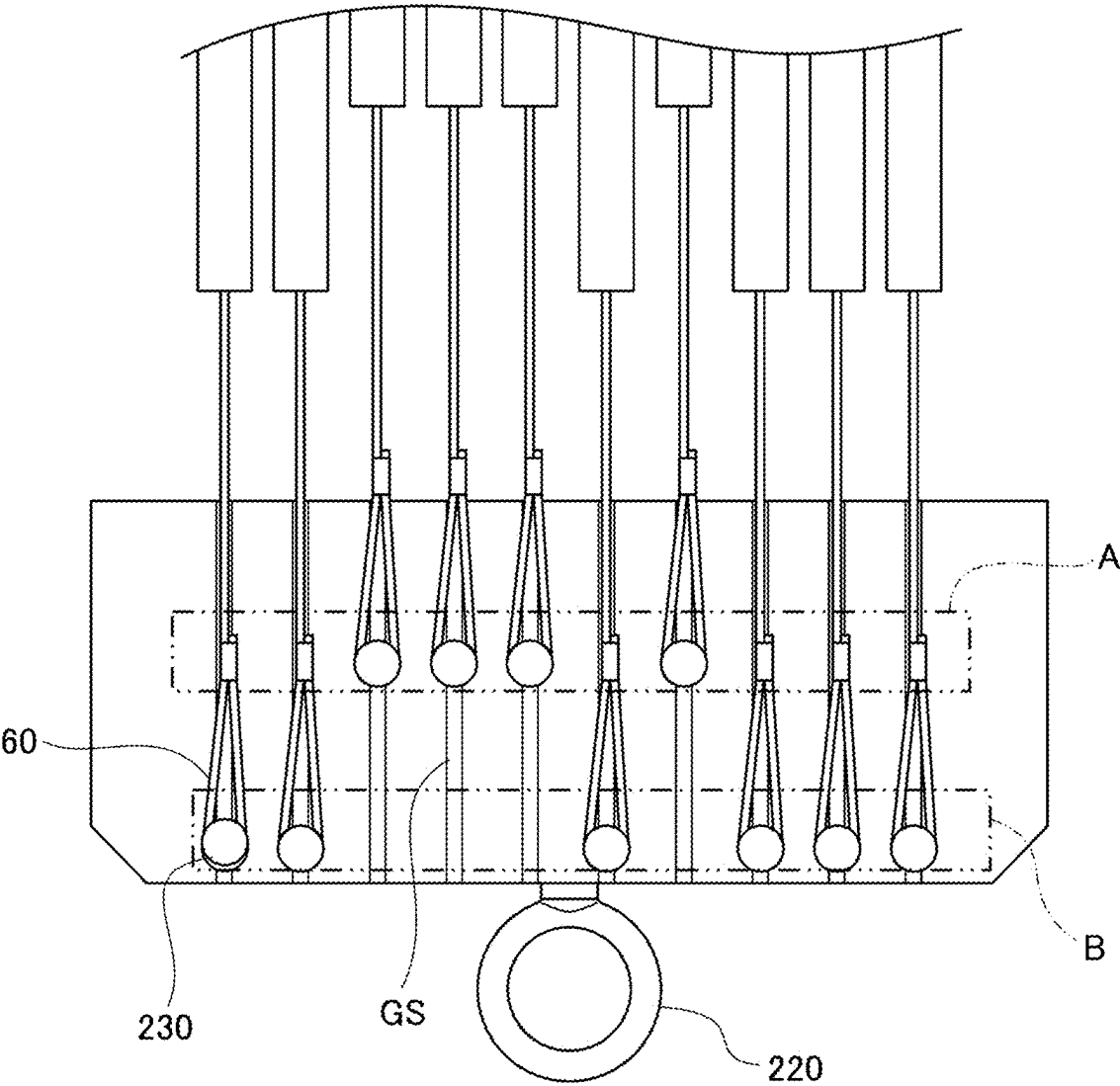


FIG. 13

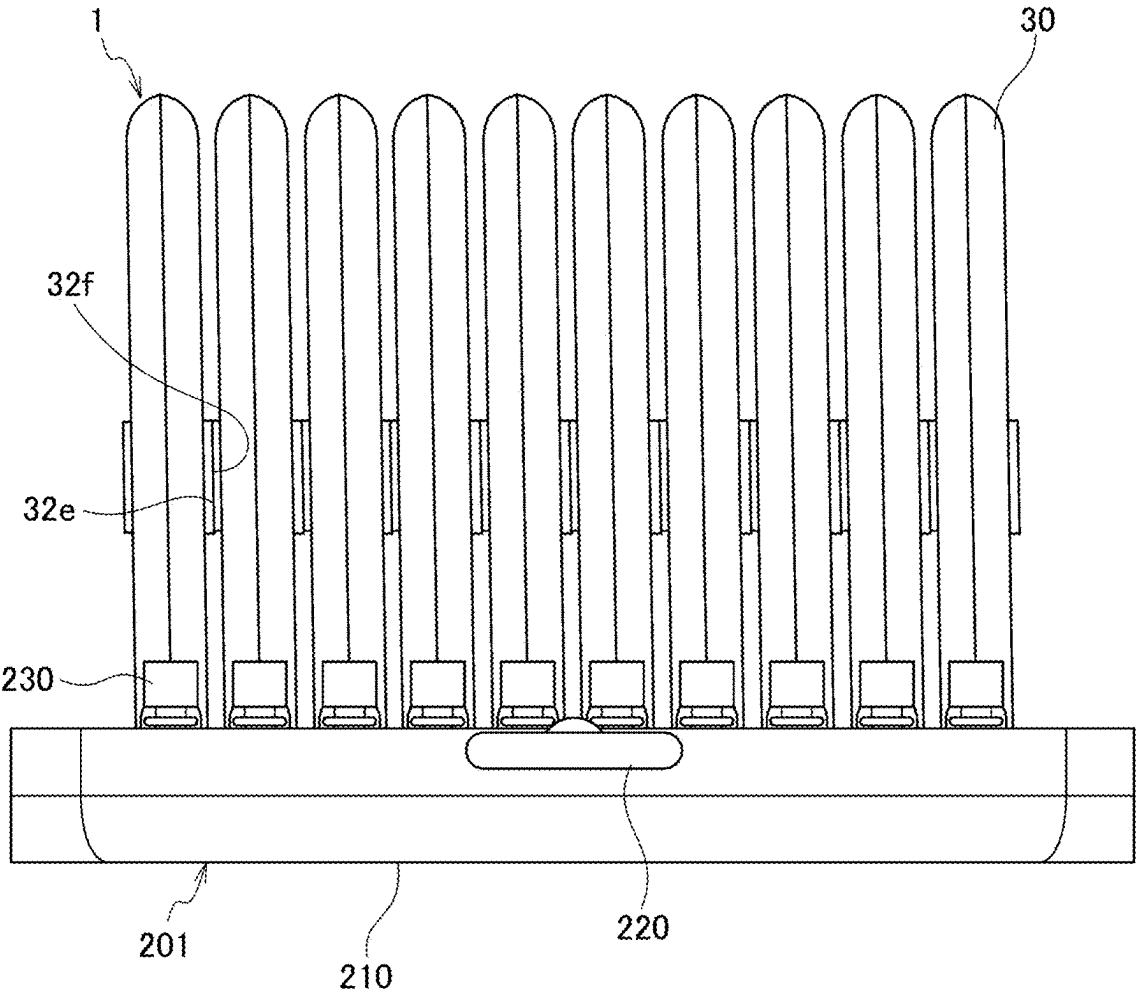


FIG.14

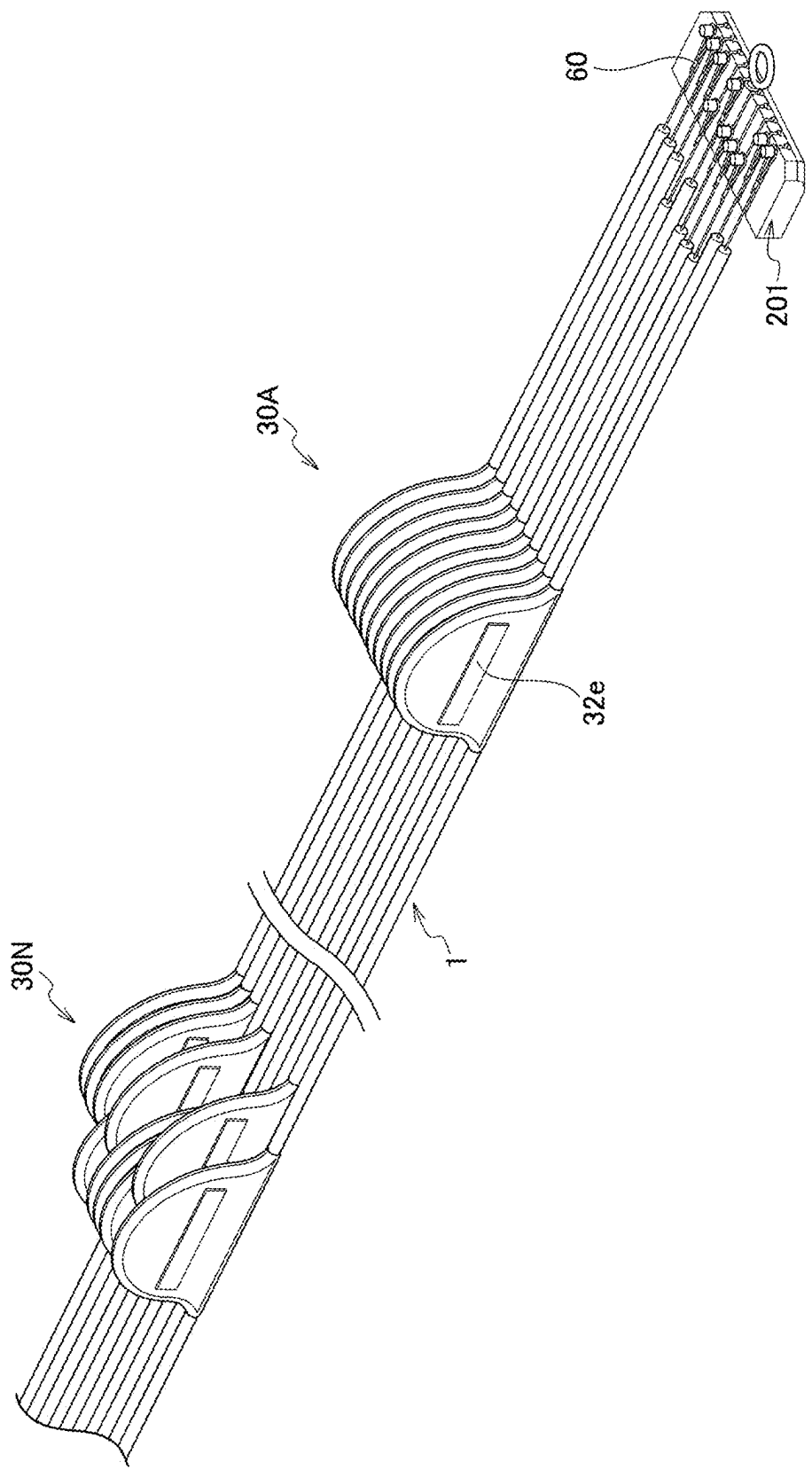
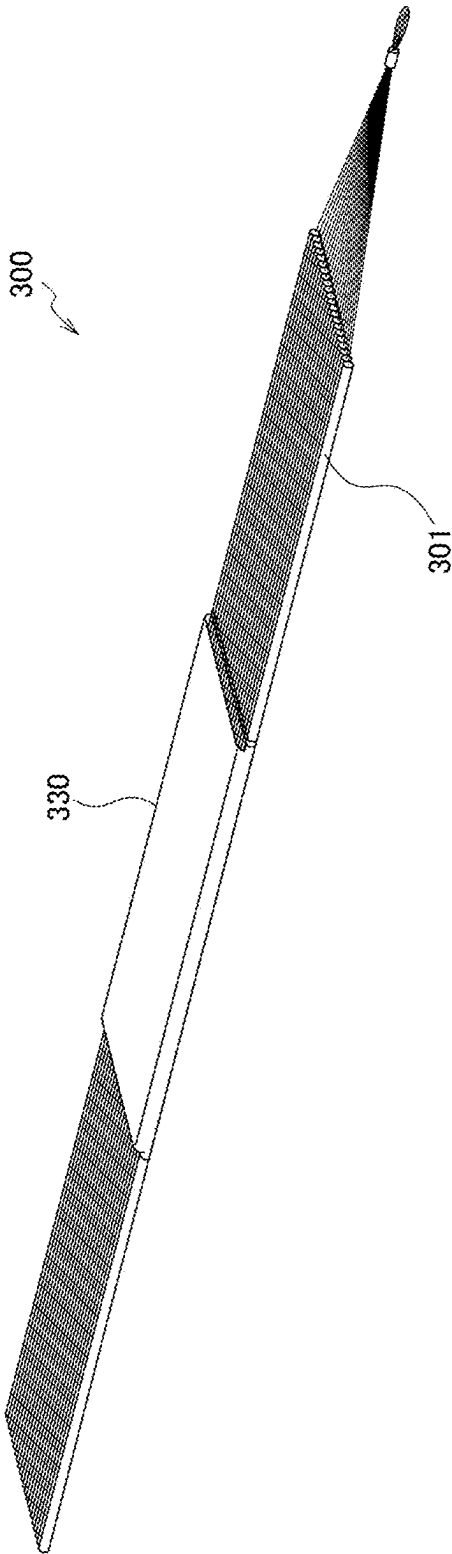


FIG.15



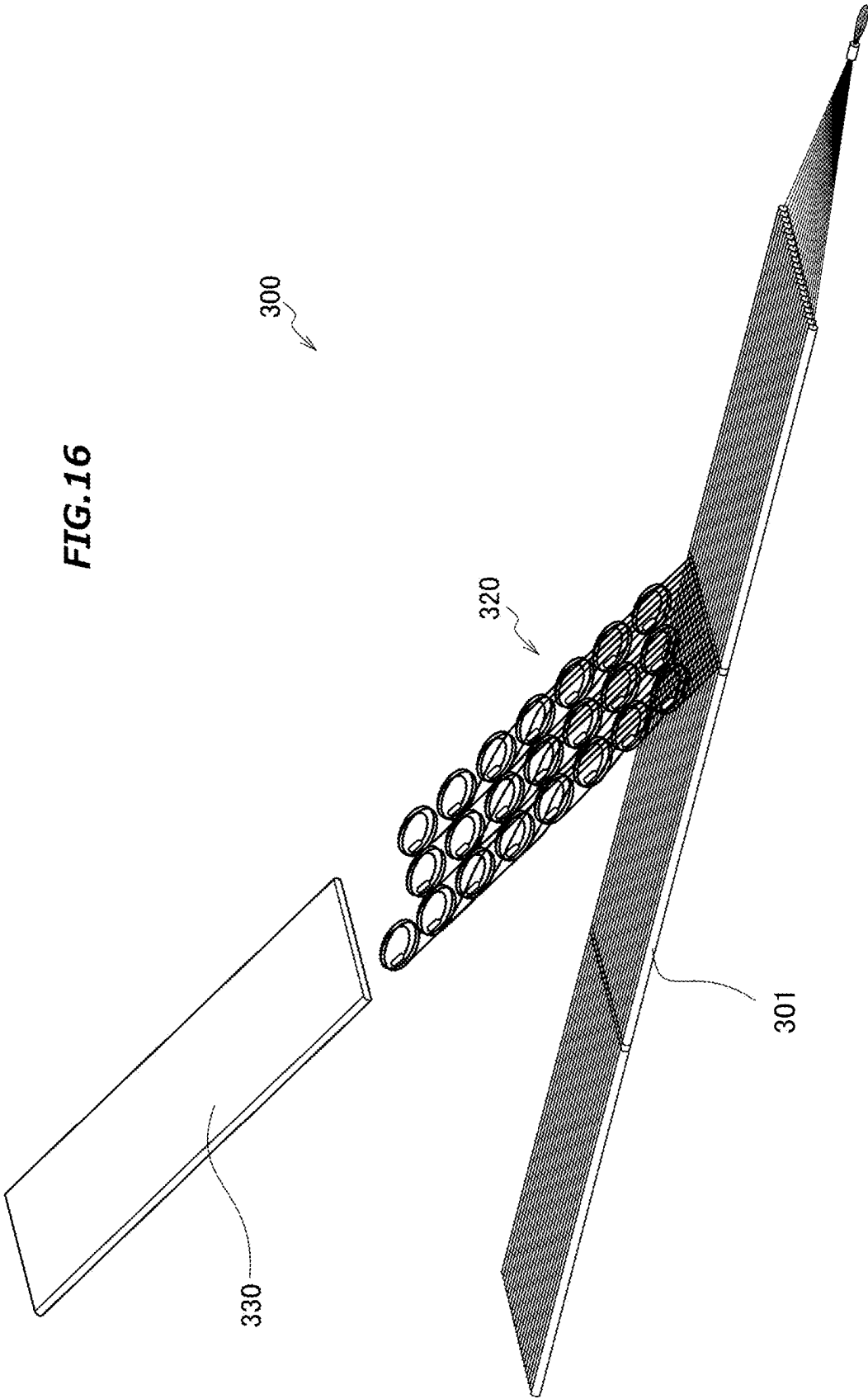
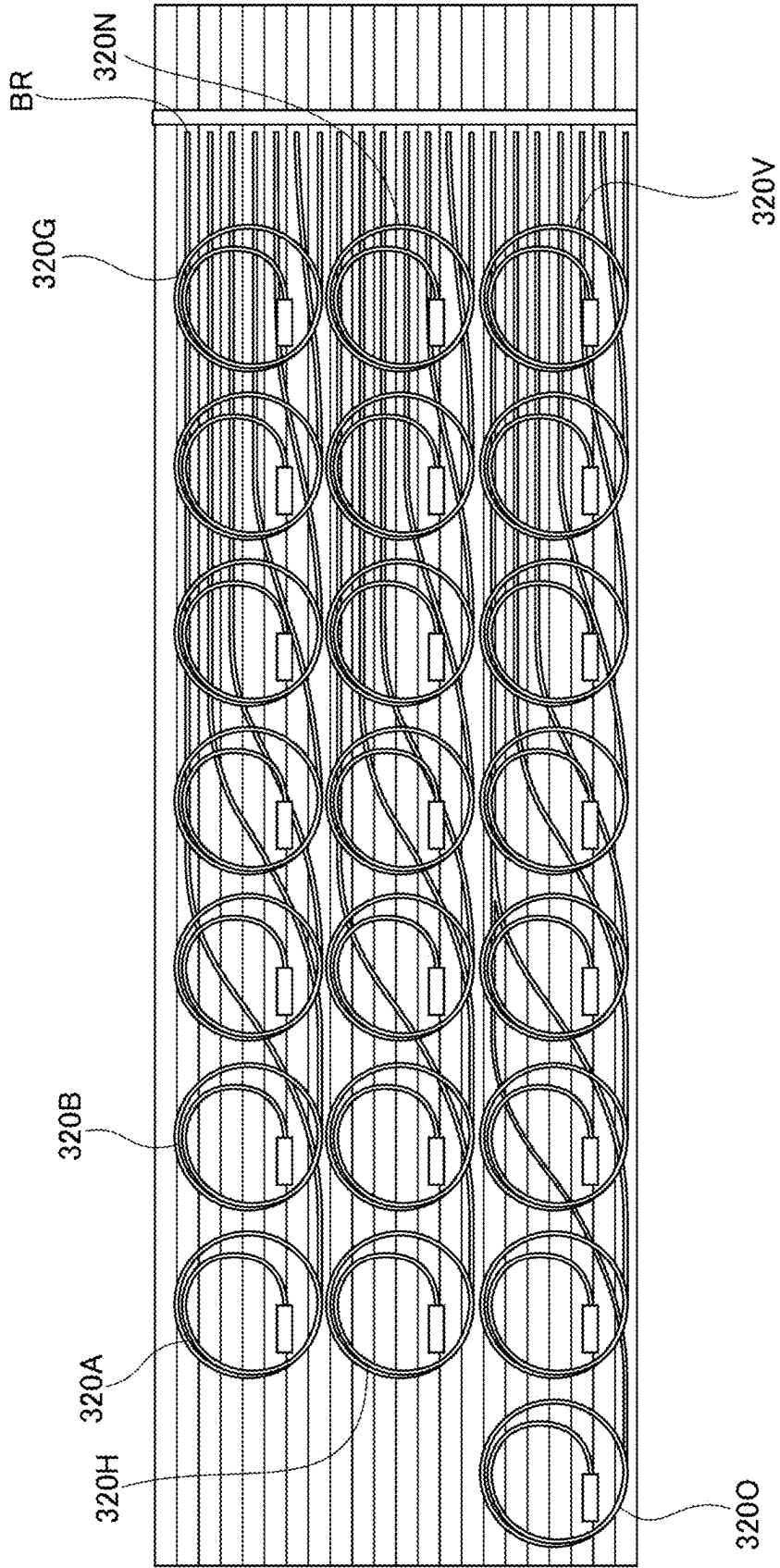


FIG.17



OPTICAL BRANCH CABLE AND OPTICAL BRANCH CABLE SET

TECHNICAL FIELD

[0001] The present disclosure relates to an optical branch cable and an optical branch cable set. This application claims priority based on Japanese Patent Application No. 2024-032396 filed on Mar. 4, 2024, and the entire contents of the Japanese patent application are incorporated herein by reference.

BACKGROUND

[0002] Japanese Unexamined Patent Application Publication No. 2023-083096 discloses an optical branch cable for connecting a server rack group including a plurality of server racks and a distributing frame. The optical branch cable includes a main cable and branch cords that branch from the main cable and are connected to the server racks.

SUMMARY

[0003] An optical branch cable according to an aspect of the present disclosure includes a main cable including a plurality of optical cords each including at least one optical fiber core wire, a tension member, and a tape forming an outermost layer, and a branch cord portion in which at least one optical fiber core wire is led out from the optical cords of the main cable to an outer side of the outermost layer. The optical branch cable includes an optical cord group including the plurality of optical cords bundled by a first bundle, and a core portion including the optical cord group and the tension member bundled by a second bundle. The tape is wrapped by longitudinal wrapping around the core portion to cover the core portion.

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

- [0004] FIG. 1 illustrates an optical communication system according to the present embodiment.
- [0005] FIG. 2 is a schematic diagram of an optical branch cable.
- [0006] FIG. 3 is a cross-sectional view of a main cable.
- [0007] FIG. 4 is a partial enlarged view of a tape.
- [0008] FIG. 5 illustrates a branch cord bag.
- [0009] FIG. 6 is a cross-sectional view of the VI-VI cross section in FIG. 2.
- [0010] FIG. 7 is a perspective view of a bending restriction member.
- [0011] FIG. 8 illustrates a bending restriction member and a branch cord portion.
- [0012] FIG. 9 illustrates an installation of an optical branch cable using a pulling jig.
- [0013] FIG. 10 is a plan view of a pulling jig.
- [0014] FIG. 11 is a cross-sectional view of the XI-XI plane in FIG. 10.
- [0015] FIG. 12 illustrates a fixed position of a connecting portion.
- [0016] FIG. 13 is a diagram of an optical branch cable as viewed of a direction intersecting a width direction.
- [0017] FIG. 14 illustrates an optical branch cable aligned by a pulling jig.
- [0018] FIG. 15 is a perspective view of an optical branch cable set according to a modification.
- [0019] FIG. 16 illustrates an optical branch cable set and a branch cord bag according to a modification.

[0020] FIG. 17 illustrates an arrangement example of a branch cord portion of each optical branch cable.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

[0021] The arrangement of the server rack in the server rack group varies depending on the intended use. Thus, the optical branch cable is manufactured such that the position where the branching portion where the main cable and the branch cord branch is provided corresponds to the arrangement of each server rack. The branch cable that is easy to manufacture is advantageous not only in that it reduces labor for manufacturing but also in that it is easy to cope with various server rack groups.

[0022] The object of the present disclosure is to provide an optical branch cable and an optical branch cable set with improved ease of manufacture.

Description of Embodiments of Present Disclosure

[0023] First, embodiments of the present disclosure will be listed and described.

[0024] (1) An optical branch cable according to an aspect of the present disclosure includes a main cable including a plurality of optical cords each including at least one optical fiber core wire, a tension member, and a tape forming an outermost layer, and a branch cord portion in which at least one optical fiber core wire is led out from the optical cords of the main cable to an outer side of the outermost layer. The optical branch cable includes an optical cord group including the plurality of optical cords bundled by a first bundle, and a core portion including the optical cord group and the tension member bundled by a second bundle. The tape is wrapped by longitudinal wrapping around the core portion to cover the core portion.

[0025] According to the above optical branch cable, the optical cord group is bundled separately from the tension member by the first bundle, making it easy to distinguish and work with the optical cord group and the tension member. Thus, the optical fiber core wire can be branched from the optical cord group to perform the work of manufacturing the branch cord portion. Since the outermost layer is wound by longitudinal wrapping to cover the core portion, the optical cord group is not embedded in the coating resin layer. Thus, by using the overlapping portion of the longitudinally wrapped tape as the starting point for the peeling off, it is possible to partially peel off and expose the optical cord to the outside. Thus, the optical fiber core wire can be branched from the main cable, and the manufacturing work of the branch cord portion can be facilitated. Compared to a case where the outermost layer is formed by being coated with a resin by extrusion molding, it is not necessary to remove the extrusion coating when the branch cord portion is taken out, and thus it is possible to reduce the number of processes related to the manufacturing of the optical branch cable and to improve the ease of manufacturing the optical branch cable.

[0026] (2) In the optical branch cable according to (1), a slit may be formed in the tape at a position corresponding to a branching portion at which the branch cord portion is led out from the main cable. The slit may extend in a circumferential direction of the main cable in a portion in a circumferential direction of the

tape. The branch cord portion may be led out from the main cable through the slit.

[0027] According to the optical branch cable, the tape can be partially peeled off by using the slit in order to expose the optical cord to the outside. Thus, it is easy to perform the manufacturing work of the branch cord portion. Since the branch cord portion branches from the main cable through the slit, the area where the inner portion of the main cable is exposed can be reduced after the manufacturing work of the branch cord portion.

[0028] (3) In the optical branch cable according to (2), the slit may be formed from an end portion in a circumferential direction of an inner layer portion to an end portion in a circumferential direction of an outer layer portion in an overlapping portion of the longitudinal wrapping of the tape.

[0029] According to the optical branch cable, since the end portion of the inner layer portion in the circumferential direction and the end portion of the outer layer portion in the circumferential direction are partially removed by the slit, the tape can be partially peeled off from the end portion of the tape in the circumferential direction by using the slit.

[0030] (4) The optical branch cable according to any one of (1) to (3) may include an optical connector provided at an end of the branch cord portion, and a branch cord bag being capable of housing at least a portion of the branch cord portion in a state of being wound in a coil shape.

[0031] According to the optical branch cable, at least a portion of the branch cord portion is housed in the branch cord bag in a coil shape, making it possible to protect the branch cord portion in a state that is easy to take off after manufacturing.

[0032] (5) In the optical branch cable according to (4), at least one surface of the branch cord bag may have a semicircular shape.

[0033] According to the optical branch cable, at least one surface of the branch cord bag has a semicircular shape, making it easy to be housed in a state of being wound in a coil shape and fitted to the branch cord portion.

[0034] (6) In the optical branch cable according to (4) or (5), an inner surface of the branch cord bag and the main cable may be coupled by a hook and loop fastener.

[0035] According to the optical branch cable, the branch cord bag and the main cable are bonded to each other by the hook and loop fastener. Thus, the branch cord bag is less likely to be displaced with respect to the main cable, and thus the branch cord portion is less likely to lose its shape from the state of being wound in a coil shape.

[0036] (7) The optical branch cable according to any one of (4) to (6) may include a bending restriction member including a mounting portion being attachable to the main cable, a bending restriction portion configured to restrict the branch cord portion so as not to bend at a radius less than a predetermined bending radius, and a main body portion formed along an outer shape of the main cable and defining, together with the bending restriction portion, a connector pass-through portion being a hole through which the optical connector is able to pass. The bending restriction member may be attached at a position corresponding to the branching portion at which the branch cord portion is led out from the main cable.

[0037] According to the optical branch cable, the branch cord portion is restricted by the bending restriction portion so as not to be bent with a radius less than a predetermined bending radius, and thus it is possible to suppress the branch cord portion from being damaged by unintended small-diameter bending.

[0038] (8) An optical branch cable set according to an aspect of the present disclosure is an optical branch cable set in which a plurality of the optical branch cables according to any one of (1) to (7) are arranged in parallel in a direction intersecting a longitudinal direction of the optical branch cable. Each of the optical branch cables includes a branch cord bag being capable of housing at least a portion of the branch cord portion in a state of being wound in a coil shape. An outer hook or loop fastener portion is formed on each of outer surfaces of the branch cord bag. The branch cord bags of adjacent ones of the optical branch cables are coupled to each other by the outer hook or loop fastener portions.

[0039] According to the optical branch cable set, in a state where the optical branch cables are arranged in parallel, the branch cord bags of the adjacent optical branch cables are bonded to each other by the outer hook or loop fastener portion, and thus the plurality of optical branch cables can move integrally. According to the present disclosure, it is easy to manufacture optical branch cable sets for simultaneous parallel installing.

[0040] (9) In the optical branch cable set according to (8), the outer hook or loop fastener portions may be formed so as to extend in the longitudinal direction.

[0041] According to the optical branch cable set, the position of the optical branch cable where the branch cord portion is formed may be shifted in the longitudinal direction depending on the optical branch cable due to manufacturing errors or the like. Since the outer hook or loop fastener portion is formed to extend in the longitudinal direction, even when the position of the optical branch cable where the branch cord portion is formed is shifted in the longitudinal direction, the branch cord bags are easily bonded to each other.

Details of Embodiments of Present Disclosure

[0042] Specific examples of an optical branch cable and an optical branch cable set according to embodiments of the present disclosure will be described below with reference to the drawings. The present disclosure is not limited to these illustrations, but is defined by the appended claims, and is intended to include all modifications within the scope and meaning equivalent to the appended claims.

Optical Branch Cable

[0043] FIG. 1 illustrates an optical communication system 100 according to the present embodiment. As illustrated in FIG. 1, optical communication system 100 includes a distributing frame 110 and a plurality of server racks 120. Optical branch cable 1 used in optical communication system 100 is connected to distributing frame 110. Server rack 120 accommodates physical servers therein. An optical fiber branched from optical branch cable 1 is connected to each server rack 120. Optical branch cable 1 is installed on a cable laying tray T and wired to distributing frame 110 and server rack 120.

[0044] FIG. 2 is a schematic view of optical branch cable 1. As illustrated in FIG. 2, optical branch cable 1 includes a main cable 10, a branch cord portion 20, a branch cord bag 30, a bending restriction member 40, an end portion bag 50, and a connecting loop 60.

[0045] FIG. 3 is a cross-sectional view of main cable 10. Main cable 10 includes a plurality of optical cords 11, a tension member 12, and a tape 13. Optical cord 11, tension member 12, and tape 13 are arranged along the longitudinal direction of main cable 10.

[0046] Each of optical cords 11 includes at least one optical fiber core wire 11A therein. In the present embodiment, optical cord 11 includes 24 optical fiber core wires 11A therein. The plurality of optical cords 11 are bundled in a first bundle 14 to constitute an optical cord group 15.

[0047] Tension member 12 is formed of, for example, fiber reinforced plastic (FRP) such as aramid FRP, glass FRP, or carbon FRP. Tension member 12 is configured to be applied with tension when optical branch cable 1 is pulled. Optical cord group 15 and tension member 12 are bundled by a second bundle 16 to constitute a core portion 17.

[0048] Tape 13 forms the outermost layer of main cable 10. Tape 13 is configured to maintain a shape covering core portion 17 by being wound around core portion 17 by longitudinal wrapping. Tape 13 is a sheet-like insulating resin, and may be formed of, for example, polyester.

[0049] Returning to FIG. 2, branch cord portion 20 is a cord in which at least one optical fiber core wire 11A is led out from optical cord 11 of main cable 10 to the outer side of tape 13 which is the outermost layer. An optical connector 21 is provided at the end of branch cord portion 20. Branch cord portion 20 may be a portion in which optical fiber core wire 11A in optical cord 11 is led out to the outer side of the outermost layer of main cable 10, or may be a portion in which optical cord 11 itself is led out to the outer side of the outermost layer of main cable 10.

[0050] FIG. 4 is a partially enlarged view of tape 13. As illustrated in FIG. 4, tape 13 is wound around core portion 17 by longitudinal wrapping, so that an overlapping portion is formed where tape 13 overlaps in double layers. In the overlapping portion, an end portion of the inner layer portion of tape 13 in the circumferential direction is referred to as a first end portion 13A, and an end portion of the outer layer portion of tape 13 in the circumferential direction is referred to as a second end portion 13B.

[0051] Tape 13 has a slit S formed at a position corresponding to the branching portion at which branch cord portion 20 is branched from main cable 10. Slit S is formed in a portion of tape 13 in the circumferential direction so as to extend in the circumferential direction of main cable 10.

[0052] Slit S is formed to penetrate the inner layer portion and the outer layer portion of the overlapping portion. Slit S is formed from first end portion 13A to second end portion 13B in the overlapping portion of the longitudinal wrapping of tape 13. In other words, slit S is formed to include first end portion 13A and second end portion 13B.

[0053] Branch cord portion 20 is led out from main cable 10 through slit S. FIG. 4 illustrates branch cord portion 20 passing through slit S by an arrow. It is noted that, the dashed line indicates that branch cord portion 20 passes through the inner side of tape 13 which is the outermost layer of main cable 10.

[0054] As illustrated in FIG. 4, branch cord portion 20 passes through the inner side of the outermost layer formed

by tape 13 before branching from main cable 10. Branch cord portion 20 is led out from main cable 10 by passing through slit S. After being branched, branch cord portion 20 is arranged to the outer side of the outermost layer.

Branch Cord Bag

[0055] FIG. 5 illustrates branch cord bag 30. In FIG. 5, the outer shape line of branch cord bag 30 is shown by a dashed line. FIG. 6 is a cross-sectional view of the VI-VI cross section in FIG. 2.

[0056] Branch cord bag 30 is configured to be capable of housing branch cord portion 20. Branch cord portion 20 is accommodated in branch cord bag 30 when it is not necessary to connect to server rack 120 (refer to, FIG. 1) during transportation or the like. Branch cord bag 30 is configured to be capable of housing branch cord portion 20 in a state where at least a portion of branch cord portion 20 is wound in a coil shape.

[0057] Branch cord bag 30 has a flat shape, with a portion of it being formed to be openable. At least one surface of branch cord bag 30 may have a semicircular shape. In the present embodiment, the outer surface of branch cord bag 30 may have two main surfaces 31. Main surface 31 is a surface having the largest area in branch cord bag 30. Main surface 31 of branch cord bag 30 may have a semicircular shape so as to follow branch cord portion 20 wound in a coil shape.

[0058] As illustrated in FIG. 6, a first hook or loop fastener portion 32a and a second hook or loop fastener portion 32b are formed on the inner surface of branch cord bag 30. First hook or loop fastener portion 32a and second hook or loop fastener portion 32b are formed at positions of main surface 31 where the opening of branch cord bag 30 is formed so that the coupling surfaces thereof face main cable 10. In the present embodiment, first hook or loop fastener portion 32a and second hook or loop fastener portion 32b form the hook surface of the hook and loop fastener.

[0059] A cable hook or loop fastener portion 18 is formed on the outer surface of main cable 10. Cable hook or loop fastener portion 18 may be provided only at a position corresponding to the branching portion. In the present embodiment, cable hook or loop fastener portion 18 forms a loop surface.

[0060] First hook or loop fastener portion 32a and second hook or loop fastener portion 32b are configured to be capable of coupling to cable hook or loop fastener portion 18. In other words, the inner surface of branch cord bag 30 and main cable 10 are coupled by first hook or loop fastener portion 32a, second hook or loop fastener portion 32b, and cable hook or loop fastener portion 18. In the present embodiment, a third hook or loop fastener portion 32c forms a hook surface of a hook and loop fastener.

[0061] As illustrated in FIG. 6, third hook or loop fastener portion 32c is formed on the inner surface of branch cord bag 30. Third hook or loop fastener portion 32c is formed to protrude in a direction of the opening of branch cord bag 30.

[0062] On the outer surface of main surface 31 where second hook or loop fastener portion 32b is provided in branch cord bag 30, a fourth hook or loop fastener portion 32d is formed. In the present embodiment, fourth hook or loop fastener portion 32d forms a loop surface.

[0063] Third hook or loop fastener portion 32c is configured to be capable of coupling to fourth hook or loop fastener portion 32d. As illustrated in FIG. 6, third hook or loop fastener portion 32c is coupled to fourth hook or loop

fastener portion **32d** by performing a coupling operation **O1** to bend the portion provided with third hook or loop fastener portion **32c** onto fourth hook or loop fastener portion **32d**. This allows the opening of branch cord bag **30** to be closed. Branch cord bag **30** is arranged to be wound around main cable **10**, making the coupling between branch cord bag **30** and main cable **10** stronger.

[0064] On the outer surface of main surface **31** where first hook or loop fastener portion **32a** is provided in branch cord bag **30**, a fifth hook or loop fastener portion **32e** is formed. In the present embodiment, fifth hook or loop fastener portion **32e** forms a loop surface.

[0065] On the outer surface of main surface **31** where second hook or loop fastener portion **32b** is provided in branch cord bag **30**, a sixth hook or loop fastener portion **32f** is formed. In the present embodiment, sixth hook or loop fastener portion **32f** forms a hook surface.

[0066] Fifth hook or loop fastener portion **32e** is configured to be capable of coupling to sixth hook or loop fastener portion **32f** of another branch cord bag **30** (refer to FIG. **13**). Fifth hook or loop fastener portion **32e** and sixth hook or loop fastener portion **32f** may be formed to extend in the longitudinal direction of main cable **10** (refer to FIG. **14**). Fifth hook or loop fastener portion **32e** and sixth hook or loop fastener portion **32f** are examples of the outer hook or loop fastener portion.

Bending Restriction Member

[0067] As illustrated in FIG. **2** and FIG. **5**, bending restriction member **40** is attached to a position corresponding to the branching portion of optical branch cable **1**. FIG. **7** is a perspective view of bending restriction member **40**. FIG. **8** illustrates bending restriction member **40** and branch cord portion **20**.

[0068] As illustrated in FIG. **7**, bending restriction member **40** includes a mounting portion **41**, a bending restriction portion **42**, and a main body portion **43**.

[0069] Mounting portion **41** is configured to be attachable to main cable **10**. In the present embodiment, bending restriction member **40** is provided with four mounting portions **41**. Bending restriction member **40** is attached to main cable **10** by sandwiching main cable **10** with four mounting portions **41**.

[0070] Main body portion **43** is formed in a curved shape so as to follow the outer shape of main cable **10**. Thus, main body portion **43** has a partially cylindrical shape.

[0071] Bending restriction portion **42** is provided to protrude from main body portion **43** in a direction intersecting the axial direction of main cable **10** when bending restriction member **40** is attached to main cable **10**. The boundary portion between bending restriction portion **42** and main body portion **43** is formed in a curved shape having a roundness so as to have a bending radius equal to or larger than a predetermined bending radius.

[0072] Bending restriction portion **42** restricts the position of branch cord portion **20** so that branch cord portion **20** is not bent with a radius less than the predetermined bending radius. As illustrated in FIG. **8**, branch cord portion **20** is led out from main cable **10** along the boundary portion between bending restriction portion **42** and main body portion **43**.

[0073] Main body portion **43** defines a connector pass-through portion **44** which is a hole through which optical connector **21** is able to pass, together with bending restriction portion **42**. When bending restriction member **40** is

attached to main cable **10**, optical connector **21** and branch cord portion **20** are passed through connector pass-through portion **44** and accommodated in branch cord bag **30** together with bending restriction member **40**.

[0074] As shown in FIG. **2**, end portion bag **50** is provided to protect the end portion of optical cord **11** that exposed to outside at the end of main cable **10** and an end optical connector provided at the end portion of optical cord **11**.

[0075] Connecting loop **60** is connected to tension member **12** exposed at the end of main cable **10**. Connecting loop **60** is a portion connected to a pulling device such as a winch. Connecting loop **60** is formed in a ring shape, and when connecting loop **60** is pulled, tension is applied to tension member **12**, so that optical branch cable **1** can be displaced.

[0076] Next, a manufacturing process when branch cord portion **20** is led out from main cable **10** will be described.

[0077] In order to lead branch cord portion **20** out of main cable **10**, optical cord **11** needs to be exposed to the outside. In the present embodiment, tape **13** is partially peeled off from the overlapping portion of tape **13** which is longitudinally wrapped, so that optical cord **11** is easily exposed to the outside. In particular, when tape **13** has slit **S** formed therein, tape **13** can be easily peeled off by using slit **S**.

[0078] In particular, as illustrated in FIG. **4**, when slit **S** is formed from first end portion **13A** which is the end portion of the inner layer portion in the circumferential direction to second end portion **13B** which is the end portion of the outer layer portion in the circumferential direction as in the present embodiment, the work of exposing optical cord **11** to the outside is easy. Tape **13** is partially peeled off from second end portion **13B** so that first end portion **13A** is exposed to the outside, and when first end portion **13A** is exposed to the outside, tape **13** is partially peeled off from first end portion **13A**, thereby easily exposing optical cord **11** to the outside.

[0079] In the optical branch cable, if the outermost layer is formed by being covered with a resin by extrusion molding, it is necessary to remove the extrusion coating in order to lead out the branch cord portion from the main cable. At this time, it is necessary to remove the entire coating of the main cable in the circumferential direction in a portion of the cable longitudinal direction, and the time and labor required for removing the coating has been a factor of increasing the number of steps in manufacturing the optical branch cable.

[0080] In optical branch cable **1** according to the present embodiment, optical cord group **15** is bundled separately from tension member **12** by first bundle **14**, making it easy to work with and distinguish optical cord group **15** from tension member **12**. Thus, optical fiber core wire **11A** can be branched from optical cord group **15** to perform the work of manufacturing branch cord portion **20**. Tape **13** of the outermost layer covers core portion **17** by being wound by longitudinal wrapping. Thus, tape **13** can be partially peeled off from the overlapping portion of tape **13** which is longitudinally wrapped, and optical cord **11** can be exposed to the outside. Thus, optical fiber core wire **11A** can be branched from main cable **10** to perform the work of manufacturing branch cord portion **20**. Compared to a case where the outermost layer is formed by being coated with a resin by extrusion molding, it is not necessary to remove the extrusion coating when branch cord portion **20** is taken out, and thus it is possible to reduce the number of processes related

to the manufacturing of optical branch cable 1 and to improve the ease of manufacturing optical branch cable 1.

[0081] In optical branch cable 1 according to the present embodiment, tape 13 can be partially peeled off using slit S in order to expose optical cord 11 to the outside. Thus, it is easy to perform the manufacturing work of branch cord portion 20. Further, since branch cord portion 20 branches from main cable 10 through slit S, the area where the inner portion of main cable 10 is exposed can be reduced after the manufacturing work of branch cord portion 20.

[0082] In optical branch cable 1 according to the present embodiment, since first end portion 13A which is the end portion of the inner layer portion in the circumferential direction and second end portion 13B which is the end portion of the outer layer portion in the circumferential direction are partially removed by slit S, tape 13 can be easily partially peeled off from the end portion of tape 13 in the circumferential direction by using slit S.

[0083] In optical branch cable 1 according to the present embodiment, at least a portion of branch cord portion 20 is housed in branch cord bag 30 wound in a coil shape, making it possible to protect branch cord portion 20 in a state that is easy to take out after manufacturing.

[0084] In optical branch cable 1 according to the present embodiment, main surface 31 of branch cord bag 30 has a semicircular shape, making it easy to house in a state of being wound in a coil shape and fitted to branch cord portion 20.

[0085] In optical branch cable 1 according to the present embodiment, branch cord bag 30 and main cable 10 are coupled by cable hook or loop fastener portion 18, first hook or loop fastener portion 32a, and second hook or loop fastener portion 32b. Thus, branch cord bag 30 is less likely to be displaced with respect to main cable 10, and thus branch cord portion 20 is less likely to lose its shape from the state of being wound in a coil shape.

[0086] In optical branch cable 1 according to the present embodiment, branch cord portion 20 is restricted by bending restriction portion 42 so as not to be bent with a radius less than the predetermined bending radius, and thus it is possible to suppress branch cord portion 20 from being damaged by unintended small-diameter bending.

[0087] It is noted that, optical cord group 15 is bundled separately from tension member 12 by first bundle 14. This prevents tension member 12 from being entangled with optical cord 11 during the manufacturing process, the installation work, or the like. If tension member 12 becomes entangled with optical cord 11, tension during installation work may be applied not only to tension member 12 but also to optical cord 11. If the tension is applied to optical cord 11, optical cord 11 may be damaged. In the present embodiment, first bundle 14 prevents tension member 12 from being entangled with optical cord 11, and thus it is possible to prevent optical cord 11 from being damaged during the installation work.

[0088] Second bundle 16 bundles optical cord group 15 and tension member 12. This can suppress differences in the relative positional relationship between optical cord group 15 and tension member 12 in the longitudinal direction of main cable 10. In the longitudinal direction of main cable 10, if the relative positional relationship between optical cord group 15 and tension member 12 is spiral, the tension applied to tension member 12 during installation may also be applied to optical cord group 15. In the present embodi-

ment, differences in the relative positional relationship between optical cord group 15 and tension member 12 in the longitudinal direction of main cable 10 can be suppressed, thereby reducing damage to optical cord 11 during installation work.

Pulling Jig

[0089] Next, a pulling jig 201 for pulling optical branch cable 1 will be described. FIG. 9 illustrates the installation of optical branch cable 1 using pulling jig 201. As illustrated in FIG. 9, a plurality of optical branch cables 1 are arranged in parallel in a state of being accommodated in a groove formed in cable laying tray T. Pulling jig 201 is used to pull optical branch cable 1 while maintaining a parallel state of the plurality of optical branch cables 1. It is noted that the plurality of optical branch cables 1 are examples of the optical branch cable set. Further, pulling jig 201 and the optical branch cable set are examples of an optical cable pulling system.

[0090] FIG. 10 is a plan view of pulling jig 201. As illustrated in FIG. 10, pulling jig 201 includes a base portion 210, a pulling portion 220, and a plurality of connecting portions 230. Base portion 210 has a width equal to or greater than a parallel state of the plurality of optical branch cables 1. The “width equal to or greater than a parallel state of the plurality of optical branch cables 1” is a width equal to or greater than the total sum of the diameters of the plurality of optical branch cables 1 in a parallel state. Base portion 210 may also have a width slightly less than the width of the groove formed in cable laying tray T, such that the base portion does not rotate in a top view relative to cable laying tray T illustrated in FIG. 9 during pulling.

[0091] As illustrated in FIG. 10, guide portions each extending in a direction intersecting the width direction are formed in the width direction (left-right direction on the page) of base portion 210. The number of the guide portions is the same as the number of connecting portions 230. In the present embodiment, the guide portion is formed as a guide slit GS which is a groove formed in base portion 210. Guide slit GS is formed to extend in a direction intersecting the width direction.

[0092] Base portion 210 includes a lower void space V below guide slit GS, and includes an engaged portion 211, which defines an upper surface of void space V communicating with guide slit GS (refer to FIG. 11). Void space V is formed along guide slit GS. Void space V is formed to be wider than guide slit GS in the width direction.

[0093] Pulling portion 220 is provided to enabling a pulling device to be connected. In the present embodiment, pulling portion 220 is formed as a ring-shaped member to be hung on the pulling device.

[0094] The plurality of connecting portions 230 are provided at base portion 210 and arranged along the width direction (left-right direction on the page) of base portion 210. Connecting portion 230, by being hung with connecting loop 60, can apply tension in the pulling direction to optical branch cable 1 when pulling jig 201 is pulled.

[0095] FIG. 11 is a cross-sectional view of the XI-XI plane in FIG. 10. Connecting portion 230 includes a positioning portion 231 and an engaging tool 232.

[0096] Positioning portion 231 includes a shaft portion 231a and an engaging portion 231b. Shaft portion 231a is able to be inserted through guide slit GS, and at least a portion of its outer surface is formed with external thread.

Engaging portion **231b** is a portion connected to shaft portion **231a**. Engaging portion **231b** is arranged below guide slit GS. Even when positioning portion **231** is displaced upward, engaging portion **231b** abuts against engaged portion **211** and is configured not able to be inserted through guide slit GS.

[0097] Engaging tool **232** is provided with internal thread that is able to be fastened with shaft portion **231a**. Engaging tool **232** is arranged on the outer surface of base portion **210** and is configured not able to be inserted through guide slit GS.

[0098] FIG. 12 illustrates the fixed positions of connecting portions **230**. Connecting portion **230** is displaceable along guide slit GS. Each of connecting portions **230** is fixable to any of at least two different positions in a direction intersecting the width direction. In the present embodiment, connecting portion **230** is fixable at a first position A on each guide slit GS or at a second position B closer to pulling portion **220** than first position A. It is noted that, first position A and second position B are indicated by dashed line frames in FIG. 12.

[0099] Referring back to FIG. 11, connecting portion **230** is fixed by the fastening of engaging tool **232** and shaft portion **231a**. By rotating engaging tool **232** in the direction where the fastening between engaging tool **232** and shaft portion **231a** is tightened, positioning portion **231** displaces upward, causing engaging portion **231b** to come into contact with engaged portion **211**. Since engaging tool **232** and shaft portion **231a** sandwiches engaged portion **211**, connecting portion **230** is fixed to base portion **210** and cannot be displaced on guide slit GS.

[0100] The release of connecting portion **230** is performed by loosening the fastening between engaging tool **232** and shaft portion **231a**. By rotating engaging tool **232** in the direction where the fastening between engaging tool **232** and shaft portion **231a** is loosened, positioning portion **231** displaces below, causing engaging portion **231b** to no longer come into contact with engaged portion **211**. When the sandwiching of engaged portion **211** by engaging tool **232** and shaft portion **231a** is released, connecting portion **230** can be displaced from first position A to second position B or from second position B to first position A.

[0101] Accordingly, as illustrated in FIG. 12, connecting portions **230** can be fixed at different positions along guide slit GS in a direction intersecting the width direction. Accordingly, the position at which connecting loop **60**, which is the end portion of optical branch cable **1**, is connected to pulling jig **201** can be adjusted for each optical branch cable **1**.

Optical Cable Pulling Method

[0102] Next, an optical cable pulling method will be described. The pulling of optical branch cable **1** is carried out while maintaining a parallel state in which the plurality of optical branch cables **1** are arranged in parallel in the width direction.

[0103] As illustrated in FIG. 12, each of the plurality of connecting portions **230** is connected to one optical branch cable **1**. In this state, when pulling jig **201** is pulled, it is easier to apply the same direction and evenly distributed pulling force to all optical branch cables **1** connected to connecting portion **230**. Thus, all optical branch cables **1** are easily displaced in the same direction by the same amount,

and the plurality of optical branch cables **1** can be pulled together while optical branch cables **1** are aligned.

[0104] FIG. 13 illustrates optical branch cable **1** connected to pulling jig **201**. FIG. 13 is a view of optical branch cable **1** as viewed of a horizontal direction intersecting the width direction. As illustrated in FIG. 13, fifth hook or loop fastener portion **32e** formed in branch cord bag **30** may be coupled to sixth hook or loop fastener portion **32f** formed in branch cord bag **30** of adjacent optical branch cable **1**. Thus, branch cord bags **30** are coupled to each other, and optical branch cables **1** can be easily maintained in an aligned state during the pulling operation of optical branch cables **1**.

[0105] When all the optical branch cables are connected to one connecting portion, the optical branch cables are pulled toward one connecting portion. Thus, the direction and magnitude of the pulling force applied to the optical branch cable vary depending on the optical branch cable. In particular, since the optical branch cables arranged at the ends are pulled in the direction toward the center, the optical branch cables may run on or intersect the adjacent optical branch cables. As a result, the parallel state of the optical branch cables may not be maintained.

[0106] Pulling jig **201** and the optical cable pulling system according to the present embodiment include the plurality of connecting portions **230** arranged along the width direction. Each of connecting portions **230** is configured to enable one optical branch cable **1** to be connected. Thus, the plurality of optical branch cables **1** can be pulled in a state where each of optical branch cables **1** is connected to connecting portion **230**. This enables the plurality of optical branch cables **1** to be pulled together with as equal force as possible, thereby improving the installation workability of optical branch cables **1**.

[0107] Further, the optical cable pulling method according to the present embodiment includes pulling the plurality of optical branch cables **1** while maintaining a parallel state by using pulling jig **201**. By using pulling jig **201**, the plurality of optical branch cables **1** can be pulled simultaneously, and thus the installation workability of the optical cables are improved.

[0108] Meanwhile, a manufacturing error may occur in a position where a branching portion is formed, where branch cord portion **20** is led out from main cable **10**, for each optical branch cable **1**. Specifically, the distance from the end portion of one optical branch cable **1** to one branching portion may be different between adjacent optical branch cables **1**. Further, the distance between the branching portions may be different between adjacent optical branch cables **1**. However, even when there is a manufacturing error, the positions of the branching portions need to be aligned to some extent in optical branch cables **1** arranged in parallel.

[0109] FIG. 14 illustrates optical branch cables **1** aligned by pulling jig **201**. It is noted that, in the illustration of FIG. 14, the positions where branch cord bags **30** are provided indicates the positions of the branching portions in optical branch cable **1**. The branch cord bag closest to connecting loop **60** of the illustrated in FIG. 14 is referred to as a first branch cord bag **30A**, and the branch cord bag n-th closest to connecting loop **60** is referred to as an n-th branch cord bag.

[0110] As illustrated in FIG. 12, connecting portion **230** is fixable at first position or second position different from each other along the cable longitudinal direction in each guide

portion. At this time, when connecting portion **230** is connected to optical branch cable **1** having a relatively short distance from connecting loop **60** to first branch cord bag **30A**, connecting portion **230** is fixed to first position A. When connecting portion **230** is connected to optical branch cable **1** having a relatively long distance from connecting loop **60** to first branch cord bag **30A**, connecting portion **230** is fixed to second position B.

[0111] In this way, by ensuring that each connecting portion **230** is positioned at the appropriate first position A or second position B corresponding to each optical branch cable **1**, as illustrated in FIG. **14**, it is possible to align the positions of first branch cord bags **30A** of optical branch cables **1** to some extent.

[0112] Further, the distance between branch cord bags **30** may be different depending on optical branch cable **1**. Even in such cases, by positioning each connecting portion **230** at first position A or second position B corresponding to optical branch cable **1**, as illustrated in FIG.

[0113] **14**, it is possible to align the positions of n-th branch cord bags **30N** of optical branch cables **1** to some extent.

[0114] As described above, in pulling jig **201** according to the present embodiment, connecting portion **230** is fixable to any one of first position A and second position B which are two different positions in the direction intersecting the width direction. Thus, even when the position of the branching portion is displaced in the direction intersecting the width direction depending on optical branch cable **1**, connecting portion **230** can be shifted, and thus the position of the branching portion in the direction intersecting the width direction is easily adjusted to some extent. It is noted that, in each connecting portion **230**, it is sufficient when it is fixable at two different positions in a direction intersecting the width direction, and the fixing positions in the direction intersecting the width direction in each connecting portion **230** may be the same or different from each other. That is, a position of a first connecting portion **230** in the direction intersecting the width direction at first position A and a position of a second connecting portion **230** in the direction intersecting the width direction at first position A may be the same or different from each other. Similarly, the position of the first connecting portion **230** in the direction intersecting the width direction at second position B and the position of the second connecting portion **230** in the direction intersecting the width direction at second position B may be the same or different from each other.

[0115] In pulling jig **201** according to the present embodiment, connecting portion **230** is configured to be displaced along the guide portion, and thus a mechanism capable of changing the position of connecting portion **230** in the direction intersecting the width direction can be realized by a simple configuration.

[0116] In pulling jig **201** according to the present embodiment, engaging tool **232** is fastened or loosened with respect to shaft portion **23 la**, and thus it is possible to realize a mechanism for displacing connecting portion **230** with respect to base portion **210** in the direction intersecting the width direction and fixing the position with a simple configuration.

[0117] In optical branch cable **1** according to the present embodiment, branch cord bag **30** is provided with fifth hook or loop fastener portion **32e** and sixth hook or loop fastener portion **32f**, which are outer hook or loop fastener portions.

In the optical branch cable set according to the present embodiment, in a state where the optical branch cables are arranged in parallel, branch cord bags **30** of adjacent optical branch cables **1** are coupled to each other by fifth hook or loop fastener portion **32e** and sixth hook or loop fastener portion **32f**. Thus, when the optical branch cable set is pulled, the plurality of optical branch cables **1** can move integrally. As described above, according to the optical branch cable set of the present embodiment, it is easy to manufacture the optical branch cable set for installing the plurality of optical branch cables **1** in a collective and parallel state.

[0118] Even when the positions of first branch cord bags **30A** are aligned, the positions of n-th branch cord bags **30N** are not necessarily aligned in the width direction (that is, completely adjacent). As illustrated in FIG. **14**, the positions of n-th branch cord bags **30N** may be shifted in the longitudinal direction of optical branch cables **1**. However, in the optical branch cable set according to the present embodiment, fifth hook or loop fastener portion **32e** and sixth hook or loop fastener portion **32f** extend along the longitudinal direction of main cable **10**. Thus, even when the branching portions are shifted in the longitudinal direction of optical branch cables **1**, branch cord bags **30** are easily coupled to each other.

Modification of Optical Branch Cable Set

[0119] Next, modification of the optical branch cable set will be described. FIG. **15** is a perspective view of an optical branch cable set **300** according to the modification. FIG. **16** illustrates optical branch cable set **300** and a branch cord bag **330** according to the modification.

[0120] Optical branch cable set **300** according to the modification includes **22** optical branch cables **301**. Optical branch cable **301** according to the modification is different from optical branch cable **1** according to the embodiment shown in FIG. **9** in that the plurality of optical branch cables **301** share one branch cord bag **330**. In other words, **22** branch cord portions **320** are accommodated in one branch cord bag **330**.

[0121] FIG. **17** illustrates an arrangement example of branch cord portion **320** of each optical branch cable **301**. For reference, optical branch cables **301** are referred to as a first optical branch cable, a second optical branch cable, . . . , and a twenty-second optical branch cable in the order of arrangement from left to right on the page of FIG. **17**. Similarly, branch cord portions **320** of the first optical branch cable, the second optical branch cable, . . . , and the twenty-second optical branch cable are referred to as a first branch cord portion **320A**, a second branch cord portion **320B** . . . , and a twenty-second branch cord portion **320V**, respectively.

[0122] As illustrated in FIG. **17**, branch cord portions **320** are arranged in three rows in the longitudinal direction of optical branch cable **301**. In the upper row, branch cord portions **320** from first branch cord portion **320A** to a seventh branch cord portion **320G** are arranged. In the center row, branch cord portions **320** from an eighth branch cord portion **320H** to a fourteenth branch cord portion **320N** are arranged. In the lower row, branch cord portions **320** from a fifteenth branch cord portion **320O** to twenty-second branch cord portion **320V** are arranged. In plan view, each branch cord portion **320** is wound clockwise in a coil shape.

[0123] Branch cord portion **320** may be arranged so that the bending radius is as large as possible. For example, in the upper row, first branch cord portion **320A** is arranged at a position farthest from a branching portion **BR**. The branch cord portions are arranged in order from first branch cord portion **320A** to seventh branch cord portion **320G**, at positions away from branching portion **BR**. In other words, seventh branch cord portion **320G** is arranged at a position closest to branching portion **BR**.

[0124] Similarly, in the center row, eighth branch cord portion **320H** is arranged at a position farthest from branching portion **BR**. Eighth branch cord portion **320H** to fourteenth branch cord portion **320N** are arranged in this order at positions away from branching portion **BR**. In other words, fourteenth branch cord portion **320N** is arranged at a position closest to branching portion **BR**. Further, in the lower row, fifteenth branch cord portion **320O** is arranged at a position farthest from branching portion **BR**. Fifteenth branch cord portion **320O** to twenty-second branch cord portion **320V** are arranged in this order at positions away from branching portion **BR**. In other words, twenty-second branch cord portion **320V** is arranged at a position closest to branching portion **BR**.

[0125] As branch cord portions **320** are arranged in this way, branch cord portion **320** arranged at the position closest to branching portion **BR** is branch cord portion **320** of rightmost optical branch cable **301** in each row. At this time, when branch cord portion **320** gets wound clockwise in a coil shape, branch cord portion **320** arranged at the position closest to branching portion **BR** is less likely to be applied to an excessive small-diameter bending load.

[0126] Further, when branch cord portion **320** gets taken out, branch cord portions **320** are arranged in order, and thus, when branch cord portion **320** is connected to server rack **120** or the like, branch cord portions **320** are hardly mistaken, and the connection work of branch cord portion **320** is easy.

[0127] In optical branch cable **301** according to the modification, since one branch cord bag **330** accommodates all branch cord portions **320**, when optical branch cable set **300** is pulled, the plurality of optical branch cables **301** are easily moved integrally.

[0128] Although the present disclosure has been described in detail with reference to the specific embodiments, it will be apparent to those skilled in the art that various changes and modifications can be made without departing from the spirit and scope of the present disclosure.

[0129] The number, positions, shapes, and the like of the constituent members described above are not limited to those in the above embodiments, and can be changed to the number, positions, shapes, and the like suitable for carrying out the present disclosure.

[0130] In the present embodiment, the case of the installation of optical branch cable **1** using pulling jig **201** has been illustrated and explained, but the cable installed using pulling jig **201** is not limited to optical branch cable **1**. For example, an optical cable without a branch cord portion may be pulled by using a pulling jig while maintaining a parallel state.

[0131] In the present embodiment, connecting portion **230** is fixable at first position A and second position B on guide slit **GS**, but connecting portion **230** is fixable at three or more

points on guide slit **GS**, and each connecting portion **230** is fixable at, at least two or more different positions on guide slit **GS**.

What is claimed is:

1. An optical branch cable comprising:

- a main cable, including
- a plurality of optical cords each including at least one optical fiber core wire,
- a tension member, and
- a tape forming an outermost layer; and
- a branch cord portion in which at least one optical fiber core wire is led out from the optical cords of the main cable to an outer side of the outermost layer,

wherein the optical branch cable includes:

- an optical cord group including the plurality of optical cords bundled by a first bundle; and
- a core portion including the optical cord group and the tension member bundled by a second bundle, and

wherein the tape is wrapped by longitudinal wrapping around the core portion to cover the core portion.

2. The optical branch cable according to claim 1,

- wherein a slit is formed in the tape at a position corresponding to a branching portion at which the branch cord portion is led out from the main cable,

wherein the slit extends in a circumferential direction of the main cable in a portion in a circumferential direction of the tape, and

wherein the branch cord portion is led out from the main cable through the slit.

3. The optical branch cable according to claim 2, wherein the slit is formed from an end portion in a circumferential direction of an inner layer portion to an end portion in a circumferential direction of an outer layer portion in an overlapping portion of the longitudinal wrapping of the tape.

4. The optical branch cable according to claim 1, comprising:

- an optical connector provided at an end of the branch cord portion; and

a branch cord bag being capable of housing at least a portion of the branch cord portion in a state of being wound in a coil shape.

5. The optical branch cable according to claim 4, wherein at least one surface of the branch cord bag has a semicircular shape.

6. The optical branch cable according to claim 4, wherein an inner surface of the branch cord bag and the main cable are coupled by a hook and loop fastener.

7. The optical branch cable according to claim 4, comprising:

- a bending restriction member including
- a mounting portion being attachable to the main cable,
- a bending restriction portion configured to restrict the branch cord portion so as not to bend at a radius less than a predetermined bending radius, and

a main body portion formed along an outer shape of the main cable and defining, together with the bending restriction portion, a connector pass-through portion being a hole through which the optical connector is able to pass,

wherein the bending restriction member is attached at a position corresponding to the branching portion at which the branch cord portion is led out from the main cable.

8. An optical branch cable set in which a plurality of the optical branch cables according to claim **1** are arranged in parallel in a direction intersecting a longitudinal direction of the optical branch cables,

wherein each of the optical branch cables includes a branch cord bag being capable of housing at least a portion of the branch cord portion in a state of being wound in a coil shape,

wherein an outer hook or loop fastener portion is formed on each of outer surfaces of the branch cord bag, and

wherein the branch cord bags of adjacent ones of the optical branch cables are coupled to each other by the outer hook or loop fastener portions.

9. The optical branch cable set according to claim **8**, wherein the outer hook or loop fastener portions are formed so as to extend in the longitudinal direction.

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